

firewalls you can use, which have more functionality than Windows' inbuilt firewall. Some of the better ones are:

- Norton Personal Firewall: It's almost a rule of thumb—all Symantec products are trustworthy and reliable. The Norton Personal Firewall is no less. It has a very easy-to-use interface and offers various levels of security with different options for each level. However, it is quite expensive, at \$49.99 (Rs 2,250).
- ZoneAlarm Pro: One of the best-known firewalls in the market today. The interface is very clean, and it offers one of the best firewall protections that money can buy. It comes with a host of security features, and is more a security suite than just a firewall. It costs \$39.95 (Rs 1,800) for one year for one PC; however, you can download the free version of the software, which offers very basic firewall features.
- Comodo Personal Firewall: This is a free personal firewall that is almost as good as the ones you have to pay for. Comodo features pop-up warnings that identify over 7,000 programs as safe (elsewhere seen only in ZoneAlarm Pro) so they don't persistently annoy you with warnings. However, it is meant only for Windows 2000 and Windows XP SP2.

8.3 Anonymous Surfing

We mentioned how firewalls can also act as a proxy service wherein the firewall essentially retrieves requested information on behalf of the user. This takes us to the concept of anonymous surfing.

As the name suggests, anonymous surfing is surfing the Net without your identity being disclosed (by hiding your IP address) to the Web sites you are visiting. Anonymous surfing works on the platform of proxy connections. This means that you are accessing the internet through a proxy server. A proxy server takes your internet requests (in the form of URLs) and retrieves the information through itself rather than through your computer. This retrieved information is therefore not displayed on